FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Relationships, Sex and Health Education Policy

Reference: FME-CU-04

Last review: September 2026
Next review: September 2027

Reviewed by: Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher
Carrie-Ann McGurk, Proprietor
Mark O'Donnell, Chair of School Governance Board

CONTENTS

1.0 AIMS 2
2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE 2
3.0 POLICY DEVELOPMENT AND CONSULTATION 3
4.0 DEFINITIONS 3
5.0 CURRICULUM 4
6.0 DELIVERY OF RSHE 5
7.0 RESOURCES AND EXTERNAL ORGANISATIONS 7
8.0 SAFEGUARDING AND CONFIDENTIALITY 8
9.0 RESPONDING TO DIFFICULT QUESTIONS 9
10.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES 9
11.0 PARENTS' RIGHT TO WITHDRAW 10
12.0 ASSESSMENT 11
13.0 TRAINING 11
14.0 MONITORING AND REVIEW 11
15.0 LINKS WITH OTHER POLICIES 11
16.0 APPENDICES 12
APPENDIX 1: CURRICULUM MAP 13
APPENDIX 2: WHAT PUPILS SHOULD KNOW 16
APPENDIX 3: PARENT AND CARER WITHDRAWAL FORM 24

1.0 AIMS

Futures Matter - Northwood is a small independent special school for pupils aged 11 to 16 with social, emotional and mental health (SEMH) needs and autism. All our pupils have an education, health and care (EHC) plan. Many have had experiences that make talking about relationships, bodies and safety hard, and some are more likely to be exploited, bullied or to behave in ways that put themselves or others at risk. Good relationships, sex and health education (RSHE) is one of the most important ways we keep our pupils safe and prepare them for adult life.

The aims of RSHE at our school are to:

- provide a safe, structured framework in which sensitive discussions can take place
- prepare pupils for puberty, and give them an understanding of sexual development and the importance of health and hygiene
- help pupils develop self-respect, confidence and empathy, and positive characteristics such as kindness and integrity
- create a positive culture and promote healthy norms about relationships, including sexual relationships where relevant, and about health, including mental health
- teach pupils the correct vocabulary to describe themselves and their bodies
- teach pupils how to keep themselves safe, including online, how to recognise when something is wrong and how to ask for help
- teach all of this in a way that each pupil can understand and use in real life, given their needs and communication

RSHE supports our ethos of helping each pupil to feel safe, valued and ready for adult life, and it is closely linked to our work on safeguarding, behaviour, personal development and preparation for adulthood.

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

This policy has regard to the DfE's statutory guidance, Relationships education, Relationships and sex education (RSHE) and Health education, which applies from 1 September 2026, and to Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026. It reflects:

- section 34 of the Children and Social Work Act 2017, and The Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health Education (England) Regulations 2019, which require us to teach relationships and sex education (RSHE) to all secondary-aged pupils, and to publish this policy on our website
- the Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014 (ISSR), including the standards on the quality of education, on the spiritual, moral, social and cultural development of pupils (which includes personal, social, health and economic education, PSHE), on the welfare of pupils, and on not promoting partisan political views or allowing political indoctrination
- the Equality Act 2010, in particular the protected characteristics and our duty not to discriminate against pupils
- the Children and Families Act 2014 and the SEND Code of Practice, which require us to make sure our teaching works for pupils with special educational needs and disabilities
- the Human Rights Act 1998

- our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy, which follows KCSIE 2026

Health education. Health education is compulsory in state-funded schools. As an independent school, our legal duty is to provide PSHE and RSHE, but we have chosen to follow the DfE's health education content in full, because our pupils need it. We teach RSE and health education together as RSHE, within our PSHE programme (personal, social, health, citizenship and economic education).

This policy is the 'statement' referred to in the 2019 Regulations. It is published on our website and, if anyone asks for a paper copy, we give one free of charge.

3.0 POLICY DEVELOPMENT AND CONSULTATION

We must consult parents and carers when we develop and review this policy, and we also consult staff and pupils. This policy has been developed as follows:

- **Review:** the PSHE Lead and the Head Teacher reviewed the statutory guidance, the 2026 changes, KCSIE 2026, the Key model policy and our previous RSE policy
- **Staff consultation:** all staff who teach or support RSHE were asked for their views on the draft
- **Parent and carer consultation:** parents and carers, and placing local authorities, were told when the draft was published, were given a sample of the resources we plan to use, and had a set period to respond with their views before we finalised the policy. **Local authority Quality Assurance visit and desktop check of policies for West Midlands LA's** The process, timeline and online Google Form we use are set out in Appendix 4.
- **Pupil consultation:** we asked pupils what they want from RSHE, through School Council and through their key adults, in ways that suit their communication
- **Ratification:** the Proprietor and the School Governance Board approved the final policy

We review this policy every year. Each September, we tell parents and carers when the reviewed policy and curriculum are available on our website, we give them a window to give their views, and we consider them before publishing the final version. Parents and carers can also see our RSHE resources at any time (see section 7), and we will explain what we teach and when at induction, at EHC plan annual reviews and on request. We will listen to concerns and beliefs carefully, but the school makes the final decision on what is taught and when, in line with our legal duties and the needs of our pupils.

4.0 DEFINITIONS

Term	Meaning
RSHE	Relationships, sex and health education. It is taught within our PSHCEE programme, and in science, functional living skills (FLS) and other subjects.
Relationships education	Learning about the social, emotional, physical and legal aspects of human relationships, including friendships, family life and relationships with other children and adults. It is compulsory and parents cannot withdraw their child.

Term	Meaning
Sex education	Learning about sexual relationships and sexual health, beyond what is covered in science. It includes learning about consent, contraception, sexually transmitted infections (STIs) and choices in pregnancy. It is compulsory for secondary-aged pupils, but parents have a limited right to withdraw their child (section 11).
Health education	Learning about physical health and mental wellbeing, and how to look after them. It includes the changing adolescent body.
PSHE	Personal, social, health, citizenship and economic education. This is the name of our weekly lessons, where most RSHE is taught.

Our RSHE will:

- give pupils the information they need to develop healthy, safe and nurturing relationships of all kinds
- focus on pupils having respect for themselves and for others
- not normalise early sexual experimentation
- cover a range of topics, including abusive behaviour, and teach pupils how to stay safe, including online
- combine sharing information with exploring issues and values
- emphasise the relationship between physical health and mental wellbeing
- aim to reduce the stigma attached to health issues, especially mental health, and discourage the use of language related to ill health as an insult
- help pupils to understand their changing bodies and feelings, how to protect their own health and wellbeing, and when a physical or mental health issue needs attention
- build on the primary health and wellbeing content that pupils have learned before they join us

5.0 CURRICULUM

Our RSHE curriculum is set out in Appendices 1 and 2. We may need to adapt it as we go, for example to respond to a pupil's needs, to something that is happening in the community or to what pupils tell us they want to learn.

We have developed the curriculum in consultation with parents and carers, pupils and staff, taking into account the age, developmental stage, needs and feelings of our pupils. Teaching is planned so the curriculum is accessible for pupils with SEND. Many of our pupils have gaps in their earlier learning, or developmental stages that are different from their age, so the school makes sure that primary content is taught where pupils have missed it, before building on it.

If pupils ask questions outside the scope of this policy, teachers answer them in an appropriate way, so that pupils are properly informed and do not look for answers online (see section 9).

We will not condone or encourage illegal activity, such as violence against people, criminal damage to property or hate crime. We will tell parents and carers in advance if we change what we teach from our published policy, and share any materials on request.

6.0 DELIVERY OF RSE

RSE is taught within the PSHE curriculum, which has weekly timetabled lessons for all pupils. Biological aspects are taught within science, some content is taught through functional living skills (FLS), English, food technology, PE, religious education (RE) and computing, and our assemblies and tutor times add to it. Appendix 1 shows what is taught and when.

We make sure that:

- core knowledge is broken into units of manageable size
- the required content is communicated to pupils clearly, in a carefully sequenced way and within a planned scheme of work
- teaching includes enough well-chosen opportunities and contexts for pupils to practise using new knowledge, so that they can use it confidently in real life
- 'over blocking' by our filtering and monitoring system does not lead to unreasonable restrictions on what pupils can be taught. The DSL and the PSHE Lead work with our IT provider and Senso so that lesson content is available, while pupils stay protected (see our Filtering and Monitoring Policy)

Teaching approaches. Our teaching is participative and interactive. It gives pupils chances to develop skills, and to discuss and think about complex relationship situations. When teaching sensitive topics, teachers use ground rules agreed with pupils, distancing techniques (for example talking about a character instead of the pupil) and question boxes, so pupils can ask anonymously. Teachers listen to all pupils' views, and encourage them to ask questions and take part. They answer questions sensitively and honestly, in a way that is right for the pupils' ages and needs. The programme is designed so that all pupils are included equally, whatever their sex or gender.

Teaching our pupils. Our pupils have SEMH needs and autism, so we teach in the ways that work best for them:

- small groups, and one-to-one teaching where needed, grouped carefully by the teaching staff, senior leaders and the DSL. Lessons may be split by gender or taught to the whole class depending on the topic and the pupils
- clear, literal language, with idioms and euphemisms explained, and the correct names for body parts used throughout
- visual supports, written and picture resources, social stories, scripts and role-play, to make unwritten social rules and boundaries explicit (for example what is public and private, who can touch whom and when, and how to tell what someone else may be feeling)
- predictable routines, advance warning of the topic, and the choice to pre-view materials, so that nothing comes as a surprise. Pupils can take a break, use a quiet space or leave the room with a member of staff if they become distressed
- a trauma-informed approach. We know that some pupils have experienced abuse, neglect, loss or domestic violence, and teachers plan with the DSL so that content is

delivered sensitively, and so that pupils who may be affected are supported before, during and after the lesson

- explicit teaching about consent, boundaries, online grooming, sexual exploitation and pressure, because pupils with SEND may be more vulnerable to these, and may find it harder to recognise them
- teaching which includes pupils who have shown, or are at risk of, harmful sexual behaviour. Their needs are planned for in an individual risk assessment and plan with the DSL, and in line with our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- learning that links to each pupil's EHC plan outcomes, especially those about preparing for adulthood, independence, relationships and staying healthy, and which is repeated and revisited so that it is remembered

Sex education. Our secondary-age pupils are taught sex education as set out in Appendix 2. This includes consent, the law, sexual health, contraception, STIs, choices in pregnancy, and the legal and emotional aspects of intimate relationships. The timing is planned for each pupil, based on their development, understanding and needs. Sex education is taught in line with the science curriculum, including human reproduction, hormones and communicable diseases.

Families. These areas of learning are taught within the context of family life. We take care so that no pupil is stigmatised because of their home circumstances. Families can include single-parent families, same-sex parents, families headed by grandparents, adoptive parents and foster carers, among others. We are sensitive that some pupils may have a different structure of support around them, such as children in care, young carers or those with kinship carers.

Equality and the law. Teachers make sure that pupils understand the importance of equality and respect, and learn about the law. By the end of their secondary education, pupils learn about the rights and protections from discrimination relating to the protected characteristics in the Equality Act 2010, including gender reassignment. We challenge derogatory language and views about all protected characteristics, and build a culture where sexism, misogyny, misandry, homophobia, biphobia, transphobia, sexual violence and sexual harassment are not tolerated.

Biological sex and gender reassignment. In line with the 2026 statutory guidance, the school will:

- make sure all pupils are taught the facts and the law about biological sex and gender reassignment, recognising that people have legal rights because of their biological sex which are different from the rights of those of the opposite sex with the protected characteristic of gender reassignment. Pupils will also be taught that people with the protected characteristic of gender reassignment, as with the other protected characteristics, have protection from discrimination and should be treated with respect and dignity
- be mindful that, beyond the facts and the law, there is significant debate on these matters
- not endorse any particular view, or teach any view as fact. For example, we will not teach as fact that all people have a gender identity

- avoid language or activities that repeat or enforce gender stereotypes, and avoid any suggestion that social transition is a simple solution to feelings of distress or discomfort
- consult parents and carers in advance on the content of any resources on these topics, and make all materials available on request
- avoid materials that use cartoons or diagrams that oversimplify these topics, that could be seen as aimed at younger children, or that perpetuate stereotypes or encourage pupils to question their gender

If a pupil raises a question about their own gender or identity, staff respond with kindness, and follow our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and our other relevant policies. They do not promise confidentiality, and they involve the DSL and, where it is safe and appropriate, the pupil's parents or carers.

Topics that cover the law. It is important for pupils to know what the law says about the topics in RSHE, so that they can tell right from wrong and have a base for deeper discussion. These include, but are not limited to:

- marriage, including forced marriage, and civil partnerships
- consent, including the age of consent
- domestic abuse, stalking, rape, sexual offences, female genital mutilation (FGM), 'virginity testing' and hymenoplasty
- sexual abuse, harassment and exploitation, including public sexual harassment, harmful sexual behaviour and online behaviours
- online behaviours, including image and information sharing, such as nudes and semi-nudes, and AI-generated sexual imagery and deepfakes. Pupils learn the law on online sexual harassment and online sexual abuse, including grooming and sextortion
- strangulation and suffocation, which are criminal offences, and how dangerous they are
- pornography
- abortion
- the protected characteristics
- the age of criminal responsibility

Inclusivity. We teach these topics in a way that considers how a diverse range of pupils will relate to them, is accessible for pupils with SEND, is sensitive to all pupils' experiences, and makes pupils feel safe and supported and able to engage with the key messages. We choose the setting that is right for the pupil, such as the whole class, a small group or targeted session, one-to-one discussion or a digital format, and we think carefully about the level of differentiation needed.

7.0 RESOURCES AND EXTERNAL ORGANISATIONS

Resources. Before using any resource, we check that it:

- is in line with the teaching requirements in the statutory RSHE guidance
- helps pupils to use their knowledge in different settings
- is right for the age and maturity of the pupils, and for their special educational needs

- is evidence-based, and contains accurate facts and statistics
- fits into our curriculum plan and is from a credible source
- works with effective teaching approaches, and is sensitive to pupils' experiences and will not provoke distress

The PSHCEE Lead assesses new resources and records the check before they are used, and the Head Teacher approves any resource on biological sex or gender reassignment. When we consult parents and carers, we give them a representative sample of the resources that we plan to use. Parents and carers can see all the RSHE materials we use on request. They cannot veto curriculum content. We comply with copyright law when we share resources, and ask parents and carers to agree, as a condition of access, that they will not copy or share the content further unless copyright law allows it.

External organisations. We may work with outside organisations, such as the school nurse, sexual health services or charities, to help deliver some parts of the curriculum. We remain responsible for the content and the way pupils are taught. We make sure that any agency and any materials are accurate, suitable for the age, stage and needs of pupils, and unbiased, in line with our duty to be politically impartial. The school will:

- check the agency's approach and resources, and only work with agencies we are fully confident in. These must comply with this policy, the Teachers' Standards, the Equality Act 2010, the Human Rights Act 1998 and the Education Act 1996, and be accessible to pupils with SEND
- ask to see materials and lesson plans in advance, review case studies and look for feedback from others who have worked with the agency
- be clear on what the visitor will say and what their position is on the issues to be discussed
- know the named individuals who will attend, check their credentials and our usual safeguarding checks for visitors (see our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy)
- make sure the visitor understands and agrees in advance how confidentiality works and how safeguarding concerns must be reported to the DSL
- do a basic online search and address anything that may concern the school, or parents and carers, and check the agency's rules on taking photos or using any personal data they get from a session (see our Data Protection Policy)
- make sure a member of school staff is in the room throughout, who can say no or, in extreme cases, stop a session
- tell all external organisations that the school must be able to share all content with parents and carers, and share external materials with them. This includes consulting parents and carers in advance on external resources about biological sex and gender reassignment

We will not, under any circumstances, work with agencies that take or promote extreme political positions, use materials made by them even if the material itself is not extreme, or work with agencies that do not allow their material to be shared with parents and carers. External speakers never replace school staff.

8.0 SAFEGUARDING AND CONFIDENTIALITY

Keeping children safe is at the centre of all we do, and RSHE is an important part of the preventive education in our safeguarding approach. Open discussion of sensitive subjects can lead to disclosures, so:

- any concern, question or disclosure arising from, or during, RSHE lessons is shared with the DSL (Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher) or deputy DSL on the same day, and recorded on CPOMS, in line with the Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- staff never promise a pupil that they will keep a secret. They explain, at the start of every lesson and in the ground rules, that they may have to pass on what they hear to keep the pupil or someone else safe
- pupils are clear how to raise a concern, make a report, or tell someone about a friend or peer, and what will happen next
- the DSL tells the PSHCEE Lead about the circumstances of individual pupils, so that lessons are planned sensitively, including where adverse childhood experiences or possible abuse may affect a pupil's experience of a topic
- child-on-child abuse, including sexual violence and sexual harassment, harmful sexual behaviour, and sharing of nudes and semi-nudes, is dealt with under the Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and our Anti-Bullying Policy
- we teach pupils that it is never the victim's fault, and we avoid any language that blames a child who has been abused

Pupils may also talk to any trusted adult at school. The DSL knows about local services, resources and issues which may be right to bring into the lessons.

9.0 RESPONDING TO DIFFICULT QUESTIONS

Pupils ask questions, and it is better that they ask us than look for answers online. The PSHCEE Lead advises staff on questions that are appropriate to answer in a group, and those that are better answered one-to-one. Staff use the agreed ground rules, and they use their judgement about whether a question should be answered straight away. They may tell the pupil that they will come back to it later, and they can discuss possible answers with the PSHCEE Lead, the DSL, a senior leader or the pupil's parent or carer. If a question is a sign that the pupil may be at risk, the staff member follows section 8. Questions are followed up, with the individual pupil, a small group or the whole class, as is right.

10.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Who	Responsibilities
The Proprietor and the School Governance Board	Approve this policy and hold the Head Teacher to account for implementing it. The Chair of the Board scrutinises reviews of content, delivery and pupil progress, and reports to the Proprietor. They make sure that: all pupils make progress in achieving the expected outcomes; teaching is accessible to all pupils with SEND; the curriculum and teaching materials are in line with the guidance; and clear information is given to parents about the content, materials, external providers and the right to withdraw.

Who	Responsibilities
The Head Teacher	Is responsible for making sure that RSHE is taught consistently across the school, that all resources and materials are shared with parents and carers, and for managing requests to withdraw pupils from sex education (section 11). Is the DSL. Makes sure staff have the right knowledge to teach RSHE.
The PSHCEE Lead	Makes sure RSHE is planned and sequenced across the year and in schemes of work, taught consistently well, and has the right resources. Checks resources, supports staff and visitors, links RSHE with other subjects, and works closely with the DSL. To confirm: the name of the PSHCEE Lead.
The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	Works with the PSHCEE Lead and senior leaders so that all parts of the curriculum are right for each pupil, plans sensitive delivery with attention to pupils' backgrounds and any adverse childhood experiences, and receives concerns and disclosures made in RSHE.
Teachers and other staff	Deliver RSHE in a sensitive, high-quality way that suits each pupil, and model positive attitudes and behaviour. Respond to the needs of individual pupils, and to pupils whose parents have withdrawn them from sex education. Monitor progress. Avoid language that could repeat harmful stereotypes, and are alert to everyday sexism, misogyny and misandry, homophobia, biphobia, transphobia, sexual violence and harassment, and derogatory behaviour. Where misogynistic ideas are expressed, challenge the ideas and not the person who expressed them. Report any safeguarding concern to the DSL. Staff do not have the right to opt out of teaching RSHE, but those with concerns should talk to the Head Teacher.
The Training Lead	Works with the Head Teacher to make sure staff who plan and deliver RSHE have the right training (section 13).
Pupils	Are expected to take part fully in RSHE and, when discussing RSHE, to treat others with respect and sensitivity.

Entries in the table above that say To confirm or Add still need completing.

11.0 PARENTS' RIGHT TO WITHDRAW

Parents and carers do **not** have the right to withdraw their child from relationships education or health education. They also cannot withdraw their child from anything taught as part of the science curriculum, including science topics on puberty or sexual reproduction.

Parents and carers can ask to withdraw their child from sex education within RSHE, up to and until 3 terms before the pupil turns 16. After this point, if the pupil wants to receive sex education instead of being withdrawn, the school will arrange this, and will make sure that pupils know they have this option.

To ask for a withdrawal, parents or carers should put their request in writing to the Head Teacher, using the form in Appendix 3. We will:

- put a copy of the request in the pupil's file
- ask the parent or carer to meet the Head Teacher, so that we can talk about their concerns and explain what is taught, how and why, and the effect that withdrawal may have on their child, including the risk that they may hear inaccurate information from other pupils or online
- give the parent or carer our decision in writing
- keep a record of the discussion and what was agreed
- give the pupil meaningful alternative learning while they are withdrawn

The Head Teacher will usually agree the request. In exceptional circumstances, for example because of a safeguarding concern or the pupil's particular vulnerability, the Head Teacher can refuse a request to withdraw the pupil from sex education. Where a pupil has an EHC plan, we also tell the placing local authority where the plan includes outcomes on relationships or sexual health. We take the pupil's own wishes into account, as far as they can understand and express them. Parents and carers can also use our online Google Form to make a request. The full process, a meeting guide for the Head Teacher, and the steps for the decision and alternative learning are set out in Appendix 5.

12.0 ASSESSMENT

There are no formal exams for RSHE, but we have high expectations of pupils' progress and outcomes, as in all subjects. Teachers assess pupils' development in RSHE within our internal assessment systems. They use question and answer, quizzes, discussion, role-play, written or visual work, self-review and pupils' views, as are right for each pupil. Progress is reported to parents and carers, and to the placing local authority, at EHC plan annual reviews and in our annual reports. Much of what pupils learn in RSHE shows in what they do outside school and as adults, so we also look at pupils' wellbeing, behaviour, relationships and safety over time and when they move on.

13.0 TRAINING

Staff are trained on delivering RSHE as part of their induction, and it is part of our continuing professional development calendar, including training on safeguarding, harmful sexual behaviour, online safety and supporting pupils with SEMH needs and autism. The Head Teacher and the Training Lead may invite visitors from outside the school, such as school nurses or sexual health professionals, to support and train staff who teach RSHE. **To confirm: any training already booked for staff who teach RSHE.**

14.0 MONITORING AND REVIEW

The delivery of RSHE is monitored by the PSHCEE Lead, with the Head Teacher, through planning scrutiny, learning walks and lesson visits, looking at pupils' work, visitor and speaker feedback, and pupil and parent feedback. The Head Teacher, the PSHCEE Lead and the DSL review each year how well the curriculum is planned and delivered, whether staff have the right skills, whether it reflects national guidance, local priorities and pupils' needs, and whether the resources are suitable and accessible. Pupils' progress is monitored by teachers.

This policy is reviewed by the Head Teacher every year, and sooner if the guidance changes. At every review it is approved by the Proprietor and the School Governance Board.

The DfE has said it will keep the statutory guidance under review, and we will update this policy to reflect any changes.

15.0 LINKS WITH OTHER POLICIES

- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Anti-Bullying Policy
- Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy
- Filtering and Monitoring Policy
- Behaviour Policy
- SEND Policy and Curriculum Policy
- Equality and Diversity Policy
- Data Protection Policy and Privacy Notices
- Supporting Pupils with Medical Conditions Policy
- Preventing Extremism and Radicalisation Policy
- Complaints Policy

References: DfE, Relationships education, relationships and sex education (RSE) and health education (statutory guidance, applies from 1 September 2026); DfE, Keeping children safe in education 2026; The Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health Education (England) Regulations 2019; Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014; The Key, RSHE policy model (ref 41682).

16.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Curriculum Map

Appendix 2: What Pupils Should Know

Appendix 3: Parent and Carer Withdrawal Form

Appendix 4: Parent and Carer Consultation

Appendix 5: Withdrawal from Sex Education: Process, Meeting Guide and Decision

Appendix 6: Sharing RSHE Materials with Parents and Carers

Appendix 7: RSHE Requirements at a Glance

APPENDIX 1: CURRICULUM MAP

This map shows when RSHE is taught in each year group. Pupils join us from different schools, so we assess what each pupil already knows and adapt this plan, including by teaching earlier content where it has been missed. Resources are available to parents and carers on request.

Year and term	Topics
Year 7, Autumn 1	PSHCEE: healthy relationships and transition. FLS: accessing the community, known and unknown people. Science: organisms, genes and circulation.
Year 7, Autumn 2	PSHCEE: self-care, support and safety.
Year 7, Spring 1	FLS: working together, tolerance, protected characteristics and the Equality Act. Science: human reproduction.
Year 7, Spring 2	PSHCEE: risks of alcohol, tobacco and other substances. FLS: eating with friends and family, a healthy lifestyle.
Year 7, Summer 1	PSHCEE: relationships and sex education.
Year 7, Summer 2	FLS: work experience, interacting formally and informally with peers.
Year 8, Autumn 1	PSHCEE: relationships and sex education. FLS: accessing the community, known and unknown people.
Year 8, Autumn 2	PSHCEE: emotional wellbeing. English: Macbeth, gender roles and sexuality. Science: organisms and genes. Computing: digital literacy.
Year 8, Spring 1	Science: human reproduction.
Year 8, Spring 2	PSHCEE: protected characteristics.
Year 8, Summer 1	PSHCEE: sexuality and consent.
Year 8, Summer 2	PSHCEE: digital literacy. FLS: work experience, interacting formally and informally with peers.
Year 9, Autumn 1	PSHCEE: peer pressure. FLS: accessing the community, known and unknown people. English: Of Mice and Men, treatment of women. Science: circulation.
Year 9, Autumn 2	PSHCEE: alcohol and drug misuse. Science: communicable diseases.
Year 9, Spring 1	PSHCEE: tackling homophobia, transphobia and sexism. FLS: enterprise, self-management and tolerating others in the workplace.
Year 9, Spring 2	PSHCEE: first aid. Computing: digital literacy.

Year and term	Topics
Year 9, Summer 1	PSHCEE: relationships and sex education. English: Romeo and Juliet, love, sex and relationships. Science: lifestyle and health, preventing, treating and curing diseases.
Year 9, Summer 2	Computing: employability skills.
Year 10, Autumn 1	PSHCEE: mental health.
Year 10, Autumn 2	Science: communicable diseases.
Year 10, Spring 1	PSHCEE: healthy relationships.
Year 10, Spring 2	PSHCEE: exploring influences. Science: inheritance, variation and evolution.
Year 10, Summer 1	PSHCEE: parenting skills.
Year 11, Autumn 1	PSHCEE: mental health.
Year 11, Autumn 2	Science: communicable diseases.
Year 11, Spring 1	PSHCEE: healthy relationships.
Year 11, Spring 2	PSHCEE: exploring influences. Science: communicable diseases.

New content for September 2026. The 2026 guidance adds or strengthens the topics below. They need to be placed in the map above. A proposed home for each is shown. **To confirm: the PSHCEE Lead agrees the term and year for each topic, and parents and carers are consulted on the resources.**

New or strengthened topic	Proposed home in our curriculum
Facts and law on biological sex and gender reassignment; protected characteristics	Years 8 and 9 PSHCEE (protected characteristics, tackling homophobia, transphobia and sexism), Year 11 revisit
Misogyny, incels and online influencers, power and consent beyond 'yes'	Year 9 PSHCEE (peer pressure, treatment of women in English), Year 10 healthy relationships
AI chatbots and fake intimacy, deepfakes, sextortion and online scams	Years 8 to 10, digital literacy and online safety in PSHCEE and computing
Strangulation, suffocation and the law	Year 10 healthy relationships, Year 11 communication and abuse

New or strengthened topic	Proposed home in our curriculum
Gambling harms, including gambling-like content in gaming	Year 9 alcohol and drug misuse, Year 10 mental health
Gillick competence, medical consent and how to use the healthcare system (GP, A&E, pharmacy, sexual health clinics)	Year 11 PSHCEE (preparing for adulthood)
CPR, defibrillators and basic first aid	Year 9 first aid (Spring 2), with a refresher in Year 11
Contraception, STIs, PrEP and PEP, choices in pregnancy, pre-conception and pelvic floor health	Years 9 to 11 PSHCEE and science, taught in small groups and at the right time for each pupil
Nicotine pouches, illicit vapes and alcohol safety (including drink spiking)	Year 7 and Year 9 substance misuse units

APPENDIX 2: WHAT PUPILS SHOULD KNOW

This is the content set out in the DfE's statutory guidance, which applies from September 2026. Pupils continue to build on what they learned at primary school. Where a pupil has not yet learned primary content, we teach it first.

Families

- That there are different types of committed, stable relationships
- How these relationships might contribute to wellbeing, and their importance for bringing up children
- Why marriage or civil partnership is an important relationship choice for many couples. The legal status of marriage and civil partnership, including that they carry legal rights, benefits and protections that are not available to couples who are cohabiting or who have, for example, undergone a non-legally binding religious ceremony
- That 'common-law marriage' is a myth, and cohabitants do not obtain marriage-like status or rights from living together or by having children
- That forced marriage and marriage before the age of 18 are illegal
- How families and relationships change over time, including through birth, death, separation and new relationships.
- The roles and responsibilities of parents with respect to raising children, including the characteristics of successful parenting and the importance of the early years of a child's life for brain development
- How to judge when a relationship is unsafe and where to seek help when needed, including when pupils are concerned about violence, harm, or when they are unsure who to trust

Respectful relationships, including friendships

- About the characteristics of positive relationships of all kinds, online and offline, including romantic relationships. For example, pupils should understand the role of consent, trust, mutual respect, honesty, kindness, loyalty, shared interests and outlooks, generosity, boundaries, tolerance, privacy, and the management of conflict, reconciliation and ending relationships
- How to evaluate their impact on other people and treat others with kindness and respect, including in public spaces and including strangers. Pupils should understand the legal rights and responsibilities regarding equality, and that everyone is unique and equal
- The importance of self-esteem, independence and having a positive relationship with oneself, and how these characteristics support healthy relationships with others. This includes developing one's own interests, hobbies, friendship groups, and skills. Pupils should understand what it means to be treated with respect by others
- What tolerance requires, including the importance of tolerance of other people's beliefs
- The practical steps pupils can take and skills they can develop to support respectful and kind relationships. This includes skills for communicating respectfully within relationships and with strangers, including in situations of conflict

- The different types of bullying (including online bullying), the impact of bullying, the responsibilities of bystanders to report bullying and how and where to get help
- Skills for ending relationships or friendships with kindness and managing the difficult feelings that endings might bring, including disappointment, hurt or frustration
- The role of consent, including in romantic and sexual relationships. Pupils should understand that ethical behaviour goes beyond consent and involves kindness, care and attention to the needs and vulnerabilities of the other person, as well as an awareness of power dynamics. Pupils should understand that just because someone says 'yes' to doing something that doesn't automatically make it ethically okay
- How stereotypes, in particular stereotypes based on sex, gender reassignment, race, religion, sexual orientation or disability, can cause damage (e.g. how they might normalise non-consensual behaviour or encourage prejudice). Pupils should be equipped to recognise misogyny and other forms of prejudice
- How inequalities of power can impact behaviour within relationships, including sexual relationships. For example, how people who are disempowered can feel they are not entitled to be treated with respect by others or how those who enjoy an unequal amount of power might, with or without realising it, impose their preferences on others
- How pornography can negatively influence sexual attitudes and behaviours, including by normalising harmful sexual behaviours and by disempowering some people, especially women, to feel a sense of autonomy over their own body and providing some people with a sense of sexual entitlement to the bodies of others
- How some sub-cultures might influence our understanding of sexual ethics, including the sexual norms endorsed by so-called 'involuntary celibates' (incels) or online influencers

Online safety and awareness

- Their rights, responsibilities and opportunities online, including that the same expectations of behaviour apply in all contexts, including online
- About online risks, including the importance of being cautious about sharing personal information online and of using privacy and location settings appropriately to protect information online. They should also understand the difference between public and private online spaces and related safety issues
- Not to provide material to others that they would not want to be distributed further and not to pass on personal material which is sent to them. Pupils should understand that any material provided online might be circulated, and that once this has happened there is no way of controlling where it ends up. Pupils should understand the serious risks of sending material to others, including the law concerning the sharing of images
- About the characteristics of social media, including that some social media accounts are fake, and/or may post things which aren't real or have been created with AI. They should also know that social media users may say things in more extreme ways than they might in face-to-face situations, and that some users present highly exaggerated or idealised profiles of themselves online
- That keeping or forwarding indecent or sexual images of someone under 18 is a crime (even if the photo is of themselves or someone who has consented, and even if the photo was created by that child and/or using AI generated imagery). The

potentially serious consequences of acquiring or generating images, indecent or sexual images of someone under 18, including the potential for criminal charges and severe penalties including imprisonment. That sharing indecent images of people over 18 without their consent is also a crime

- How to seek support. They should also understand that they will not be in trouble for asking for help, either at school or with the police, if an image of themselves has been shared
- What to do and how to report when they are concerned about material that has been circulated, including personal information, images or videos, and how to manage issues online
- About the prevalence of deepfakes including videos and photos, how deepfakes can be used maliciously as well as for entertainment, the harms that can be caused by deepfakes and how to identify them
- That the internet contains inappropriate and upsetting content, some of which is illegal, including unacceptable content that encourages misogyny, violence or use of weapons
- Where to go for advice and support about something they have seen online. Pupils should understand that online content can present a distorted picture of the world and normalise or glamourise behaviours which are unhealthy and wrong
- That social media can lead to escalations in conflicts, how to avoid these escalations and where to go for help and advice
- How to identify when technology and social media is used as part of bullying, harassment, stalking, coercive and controlling behaviour, and other forms of abusive and/or illegal behaviour and how to seek support about concerns
- That pornography, and other online content, often presents a distorted picture of people and their sexual behaviours and can negatively affect how people behave towards sexual partners. That this can affect people who see pornographic content accidentally, as well as those who see it deliberately. That pornography can also portray misogynistic behaviours and attitudes which can negatively influence those who see it
- How information and data is generated, collected, shared and used online
- That websites may share personal data about their users, and information collected on their internet use, for commercial purposes (for example, to enable targeted advertising)
- That criminals can operate online scams, such as using fake websites or emails to extort money or valuable personal information. This information can be used to the detriment of the person or wider society. About risks of sextortion, how to identify online scams relating to sex, and how to seek support if they have been scammed or involved in sextortion
- That AI chatbots are an example of how AI is rapidly developing, and that these can pose risks by creating fake intimacy or offering harmful advice. That it is important to be able to critically think about new types of technology as they appear online and how they might pose a risk

Being safe

- How to recognise, respect and communicate consent and boundaries in relationships, including in early romantic relationships (in all contexts, including online) and early sexual relationships that might involve kissing or touching. That kindness and care for others requires more than just consent
- That there are a range of strategies for identifying, resisting and understanding pressure in relationships from peers or others, including sexual pressure, and how to avoid putting pressure on others
- How to determine whether other children, adults or sources of information are trustworthy, how to judge when a relationship is unsafe (and recognise this in the relationships of others); how to seek help or advice, including reporting concerns about others if needed
- How to increase their personal safety in public spaces, including when socialising with friends, family, the wider community or strangers. About ways of seeking help when needed and how to report harmful behaviour. That there are strategies they can use to increase their safety, and that this does not mean they will be blamed if they are victims of harmful behaviour. About the importance of trusting their instincts when something doesn't feel right, and they should understand that in some situations a person might appear trustworthy but have harmful intentions
- What constitutes sexual harassment or sexual violence, and that such behaviour is unacceptable, emphasising that it is never the fault of the person experiencing it
- That sexual harassment includes unsolicited sexual language, attention or touching, taking and/or sharing intimate or sexual images without consent, public sexual harassment, pressuring other people to do sexual things, and upskirting
- About concepts, laws and where to find support relating to:
- Sexual violence, including rape and sexual assault
- Harmful sexual behaviour, which includes all types of sexual harassment and sexual violence among young people but also includes other forms of concerning behaviour like using age-inappropriate sexual language
- Domestic abuse, including controlling or coercive behaviour, emotional, sexual, economic or physical abuse, and violent or threatening behaviour
- Harms which are exploitative, including sexual exploitation, criminal exploitation and abuse, grooming, and financial exploitation
- Forced marriage
- The physical and emotional damage which can be caused by female genital mutilation (FGM), virginity testing and hymenoplasty, where to find support, and the law around these areas. This should include that it is a criminal offence for anyone to perform or assist in the performance of FGM, virginity testing or hymenoplasty, in the UK or abroad, or to fail to protect a person under 16 for whom they are responsible
- That fixated, obsessive, unwanted and repeated behaviours can be criminal, and where to get help if needed
- That strangulation and suffocation are criminal offences, and that strangulation (applying pressure to the neck) is an offence, regardless of whether it causes injury
- That any activity that involves applying force or pressure to someone's neck or covering someone's mouth and nose is dangerous and can lead to serious injury or death

- That pornography presents some activities as normal which many people do not and will never engage in, some of which can be emotionally and/or physically harmful
- How to seek support for their own worrying or abusive behaviour, or for worrying or abusive behaviour they have experienced from others, including information on where to report abuse and where to seek medical attention when required, for example after an assault

Intimate and sexual relationships, including sexual health

- That sex, for people who feel ready and are over the age of consent, can and should be enjoyable and positive
- The law about the age of consent, that they have a choice about whether to have sex, that many young people wait until they are older, and that people of all ages can enjoy intimate and romantic relationships without sex
- About sexual consent and their capacity to give, withhold or remove consent at any time, even if initially given, as well as the considerations that people might take into account prior to sexual activity, such as the law, their faith and family values. That kindness and care for others require more than just consent
- That all aspects of health can be affected by choices they make in sex and relationships, positively or negatively, e.g. physical, emotional, mental, sexual and reproductive health and wellbeing
- That some sexual behaviours can be harmful
- The facts about the full range of contraceptive choices, efficacy and options available, including male and female condoms, and signposting towards medically accurate online information about sexual and reproductive health to support contraceptive decision making
- That there are choices in relation to pregnancy. Pupils should be given medically and legally accurate and impartial information on all options, including keeping the baby, adoption, abortion and where to get further help
- How the different sexually transmitted infections (STIs), including HIV/AIDs, are transmitted. How risk can be reduced through safer sex (including through condom use)
- About the use and availability of the HIV prevention drugs Pre-Exposure Prophylaxis (PrEP) and post exposure prophylaxis (PEP), and how and where to access them. The importance of, and facts about, regular testing and the role of stigma
- About the prevalence of STIs, the short and long-term impact they can have on those who contract them, and key facts about treatment
- How the use of alcohol and drugs can lead people to take risks in their sexual behaviour
- How and where to seek support for concerns around sexual relationships including sexual violence or harms
- How to counter misinformation, including signposting towards medically accurate information and further advice, and where to access confidential sexual and reproductive health advice and treatment

Mental wellbeing

- How to talk about their emotions accurately and sensitively, using appropriate vocabulary
- The benefits and importance of physical activity, sleep, time outdoors, community participation and volunteering or acts of kindness for mental wellbeing and happiness
- That happiness is linked to being connected to others. Pupils should be supported to understand what makes them feel happy and what makes them feel unhappy, while recognising that loneliness can be for most people an inevitable part of life at times and is not something of which to be ashamed
- That worrying and feeling down are normal, can affect everyone at different times and are not in themselves a sign of a mental health condition, and that managing those feelings can be helped by seeing them as normal
- Characteristics of common types of mental ill health (e.g. anxiety and depression), including carefully-presented factual information about the prevalence and characteristics of more serious mental health conditions. This should not be discussed in a way that encourages normal feelings to be labelled as mental health conditions
- How to critically evaluate which activities will contribute to their overall wellbeing
- How to overcome anxiety or other barriers to participating in fun, enjoyable or rewarding activities - that it's possible to overcome those barriers using coping strategies, and that finding the courage to participate in activities which initially feel challenging may decrease anxiety over time rather than increasing it.
- That gambling can lead to serious mental health harms, including anxiety, depression, and suicide, and that some gambling products are more likely to cause these harms than others
- That the co-occurrence of alcohol/drug use and poor mental health is common and that the relationship is bi-directional: mental health problems can increase the risk of alcohol/drug use, and alcohol/drug use can trigger mental health problems or exacerbate existing ones
- That stopping smoking can improve people's mental health and decrease anxiety

Wellbeing online

- About the benefits of limiting time spent online, the risks of excessive time spent on electronic devices and the impact of positive and negative content online on their own and others' mental and physical wellbeing
- The similarities and differences between the online world and the physical world, including: the impact of unhealthy or obsessive comparison with others online (including through setting unrealistic expectations for body image); how people may curate a specific image of their life online; the impact that an over-reliance on online relationships, including relationships formed through social media, can have
- How to identify harmful behaviours online (including bullying, abuse or harassment) and how to report, or find support, if they have been affected by those behaviours
- About the risks related to online gambling and gambling-like content within gaming, including the accumulation of debt
- How advertising and information is targeted at them and how to be a discerning consumer of information online, understanding the prevalence of misinformation and disinformation online, including conspiracy theories

- About the risks of illegal behaviours online, including drug and knife supply or the sale or purchasing of illicit drugs online
- About the serious risks of viewing online content that promotes self-harm, suicide or violence, including how to safely report this material and how to access support after viewing it

Physical health and fitness

- The characteristics of a healthy lifestyle, including physical activity and maintaining a healthy weight, including the links between an inactive lifestyle and ill-health, including cardiovascular ill-health
- Factual information about the prevalence and characteristics of more serious health conditions
- That physical activity can promote wellbeing and combat stress
- The science relating to blood, organ and stem cell donation

Healthy eating

- How to maintain healthy eating and the links between a poor diet and health risks, including tooth decay, unhealthy weight gain, and cardiovascular disease
- The risks of unhealthy weight gain, including increased risks of cancer, type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease
- About the impacts of alcohol on diet and unhealthy weight gain

Drugs, alcohol, tobacco and vaping

- The facts about which drugs are illegal, the risks of taking illegal drugs, including the increased risk of potent synthetic drugs being added to illegal drugs, the risks of illicit vapes containing drugs, illicit drugs and counterfeit medicines, and the potential health harms, including the link to poor mental health
- About the law relating to the supply and possession of illegal substances
- About the physical and psychological risks associated with alcohol consumption
- What constitutes low risk alcohol consumption in adulthood, and the legal age of sale for alcohol in England
- How to increase personal safety while drinking alcohol, including how to decrease the risks of having a drink spiked or of poisoning from potentially fatal substances such as methanol
- About the physical and psychological consequences of problem-use of alcohol, including alcohol dependency
- About the dangers of the misuse of prescribed and over-the-counter medicines
- The facts about the multiple serious harms from smoking tobacco (particularly the link to lung cancer and cardiovascular disease), the benefits of quitting and how to access support to do so
- The facts about vaping, including the harms posed to young people, and the role that vapes can play in helping adult smokers to quit

Health protection and prevention, and understanding the healthcare system

- Personal hygiene, germs and how they are spread, including bacteria and viruses, treatment and prevention of infection, and about antibiotics
- Dental health and the benefits of good oral hygiene, including brushing teeth twice a day with fluoride toothpaste and cleaning between teeth, reducing consumption of sugar-containing food and drinks, and regular check-ups at the dentist
- How and when to self-care for minor ailments, and the role of pharmacists as knowledgeable healthcare professionals
- The importance of taking responsibility for their own health, and the benefits of regular self-examination and screening
- The facts and scientific evidence relating to vaccination, immunisation and antimicrobial resistance. The introduction of topics relating to vaccination and immunisation should be aligned with when vaccinations are offered to pupils
- The importance of sufficient good-quality sleep for good health, the importance of screen-free time before bed and removing phones from the bedroom, and how a lack of sleep can affect weight, mood and ability to learn
- The importance of healthy behaviours before and during pregnancy, including the importance of pre-conception health, including taking folic acid. The importance of pelvic floor health. Information on miscarriage and pregnancy loss, and how to access care and support
- How to navigate their local healthcare system: what a GP is; when to use A&E / minor injuries; accessing sexual health and family planning clinics; the role of local pharmacies; and how to seek help via local third sector partners which may have specialist services
- The concept of Gillick competence. That the legal age of medical consent is 16. That before this, a child's parents will have responsibility for consenting to medical treatment on their behalf unless they are Gillick competent to take this decision for themselves. Pupils should understand the circumstances in which someone over 16 may not be deemed to have capacity to make decisions about medical treatment

Personal safety

- How to identify risk and manage personal safety in increasingly independent situations, including around roads, railways - including level crossings - and water (including the water safety code), and in unfamiliar social or work settings (for example the first time a young person goes on holiday without their parents)
- How to recognise and manage peer influence in relation to risk-taking behaviour and personal safety, including peer influence online and on social media
- How to develop key social and emotional skills that will increase pupils' safety from involvement in conflict and violence. These include skills to support self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, relationship skills and responsible decision making, as well as skills to recognise and manage peer pressure
- Understanding which trusted adults they can talk to if pupils are worried about violence and/or knife crime
- The law as it relates to knives and violence. Content and examples should relate to the local context and avoid using fear as an educational tool. Children should be taught that carrying weapons is uncommon, and should not be scared into the

perception that many young people are carrying knives (which can lead to the misconception that they need to carry a knife too)

- The risks and signs that they may be at risk of grooming or exploitation, and how to seek help where there is a concern

Basic first aid

- Basic treatment for common injuries and ailments
- Life-saving skills, including how to administer CPR
- The purpose of defibrillators, when one might be needed and who can use them

Developing bodies

- The main changes which take place in males and females, and the implications for emotional and physical health
- The facts about puberty, the changing adolescent body, including brain development
- About menstrual and gynaecological health, including: what is an average period; period problems such as premenstrual syndrome; heavy menstrual bleeding; endometriosis; and polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS). When to seek help from healthcare professionals
- The facts about reproductive health, including fertility and menopause, and the potential impact of lifestyle on fertility for men and women

APPENDIX 3: PARENT AND CARER WITHDRAWAL FORM

Parents and carers can ask to withdraw their child from sex education within RSHE. Please read section 11 of our RSHE policy first. Sex education does not include relationships education, health education or anything taught in science, which cannot be withdrawn. If you would like to talk about this before you complete the form, please contact the Head Teacher on 0121 835 1360 or at office@futuresmattereducation.co.uk. To make a request online, use our Google Form (**To confirm: add the Google Form link**). This page is the paper version, and the school's record of each request.

TO BE COMPLETED BY PARENTS AND CARERS	
Name of pupil, and year group:	
Name of parent or carer:	
Date:	
Reason for withdrawing the pupil from sex education within RSHE:	
Any other information you would like the school to consider:	
Signature of parent or carer:	
TO BE COMPLETED BY THE SCHOOL	
Date the request was received, and date of the meeting with the parent or carer:	
Notes from the discussion, including the pupil's views:	
Decision and agreed actions (for example, the alternative learning the pupil will do while their classmates are taught sex education):	
Date the decision was sent to the parent or carer, and who signed it:	
Pupil's wish to opt in to sex education (from 3 terms before their 16th birthday), if any:	

APPENDIX 4: PARENT AND CARER CONSULTATION

This appendix sets out how we consult parents and carers when we develop or review this policy. It is adapted for Futures Matter - Northwood from The Key's guidance on running a parent and carer consultation. We must proactively engage and consult parents and carers, and we publish the policy on our website and give a copy to anyone who asks. Parents and carers cannot veto what we teach, but their views are heard and recorded, and we consider them before the policy is finalised.

Our approach. We use an online Google Form, backed up by a conversation (in person, by phone or by video call) for any family who prefers it or who would find a form hard to complete. Because our pupils all have EHC plans and many families have their own experience of the SEND system, we make sure the views we collect include families of pupils with a range of needs, and the placing local authorities.

Aims of the consultation.

- make sure parents and carers know what we teach in RSHE, and why it matters for our pupils
- listen to their views, concerns and suggestions, and record them
- find out what support families would like, for example with talking to their child at home
- build trust, so that families feel able to raise a concern early rather than only through a withdrawal request

Timeline.

- **Week 1:** the Head Teacher and PSHCEE Lead finalise the draft policy, the curriculum map (Appendix 1) and a representative sample of resources. The consultation letter, the Google Form and the draft policy are sent to all parents, carers and placing local authorities, and published on the website.
- **Weeks 1 to 3 (at least three weeks):** the Google Form stays open. Families can also ask for a call or a meeting with the Head Teacher or PSHCEE Lead, or a hard copy of the form.
- **During the consultation:** we offer an information session, in person or online, where parents and carers can see the sample resources, hear what is taught and when, and ask questions. We also offer short discussion groups of about 8 to 10 people, with a note-taker, and we invite a mix of families, including those of pupils in different year groups and with different needs.
- **Week 4:** the Head Teacher and PSHCEE Lead read all responses and notes together and prepare a short summary of what parents and carers said, and what we will change (or why we will not).
- **Week 5:** the Proprietor and the School Governance Board approve the final policy. We tell parents and carers that it is published and what changed, and we share the summary of what they said.

Consultation letter wording. The letter we send says that:

- we are reviewing our RSHE policy and curriculum, which must follow the DfE's statutory guidance that applies from 1 September 2026
- the draft policy, the curriculum map and a sample of the resources are available (by link, in the information session and on request)

- parents and carers have at least three weeks to respond, using the Google Form, by phone or in a meeting
- parents and carers can ask to see all the materials we use at any time
- we want to hear their views, although the final decision on what is taught rests with the school, in line with our legal duties
- who to contact: the Head Teacher, on 0121 835 1360 or at office@futuresmattereducation.co.uk

Google Form: parent and carer consultation. The form is created in the school's Google account. Responses go to a school-controlled spreadsheet that only the Head Teacher and PSHCEE Lead can open. Name and contact details are optional, because some families prefer to respond anonymously, and the form says who will see the answers and how long we keep them (see our Privacy Notices). Link to the form: **To confirm: add the Google Form link**. Questions, kept open-ended so that parents and carers can say what matters to them:

- What is your relationship to the pupil, and which year group are they in? (Optional)
- Having read the draft policy and the curriculum map, what do you think about what we plan to teach?
- Is there anything in the policy, the curriculum or the sample resources that you would like us to explain further, or that worries you?
- Is there anything you think is missing, or that you would like us to teach about?
- What would help you to talk with your child at home about these topics (for example, an information evening, a guide or a list of websites)?
- Do you have any other comments, or would you like someone to contact you? (Optional: name and best contact details)

Template consultation letter. Adapted from The Key's template letter, this goes to all parents, carers and placing local authorities with the draft policy:

Dear parents and carers,

We are reviewing our relationships, sex and health education (RSHE) curriculum and policy, so that we can be sure our provision is right for our pupils, based on their age and stage of development, their physical and emotional maturity, their religious and cultural backgrounds, and their special educational needs and disabilities (SEND). We need your feedback to help us do this.

Here is how you can help. You can complete our short online form (**To confirm: add the Google Form link**), which is open until **To confirm: closing date**. We are also holding **To confirm: information session and/or focus group, with date, time and place or online platform**. If you would like to attend, please email office@futuresmattereducation.co.uk or call the school office on 0121 835 1360 before **To confirm: deadline date**. Sessions take no more than about an hour. A focus group is around 8 to 10 parents and carers, plus members of our senior leadership team.

To help you understand what we are required to teach, please read the enclosed summary of what all pupils are expected to know by the end of secondary school (Appendix 2 of the policy). If you are joining a focus group, please read it before the meeting.

We also want to hear your thoughts on our curriculum and RSHE policy throughout the year. **To confirm: planned parent and carer forums or other ways to engage**. Thank you for your time.

Yours sincerely, Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher

Statements for the Google Form. Adapted from The Key's parent and carer survey pack, we add these statements before the open questions, each answered Strongly agree, Agree, Disagree, Strongly disagree or Don't know:

- My child feels safe in school
- My child knows who to speak to if they are upset or unhappy at school
- The school teaches my child how to recognise risks to their wellbeing, both online and offline
- The school teaches my child how to keep physically and mentally healthy
- The school teaches my child about healthy relationships and sex education in a way that suits their age and needs
- The school teaches my child to stay safe online
- The school offers me opportunities to find out how to keep my child safe online
- The school teaches my child to treat people of other genders with respect
- The school teaches my child to have an interest in, and respect for, different people's faiths, feelings and values
- The school values everyone equally and teaches pupils that difference is a positive, not a negative
- The school makes me aware of what my child will learn during the year
- I know who to talk to if I have a concern about my child or their learning
- My opinions are taken seriously by my child's teachers
- I feel involved in my child's education

The Key's survey template also asks about the school's greatest strengths and what could be improved. We use the open questions above instead, so that responses stay focused on RSHE.

What we do with the responses. The PSHCEE Lead groups the responses into themes. The Head Teacher records the summary and any decisions, including where we changed the policy or curriculum as a result. The summary and the date of the consultation are entered in section 3.0 of the policy. Where responses show a concern about a particular topic or resource, we explain what we teach and why, and where we can (without breaching our legal duties) we consider changing the resource.

Record of consultation. To confirm: dates of the current consultation, number of responses and a short summary of what parents and carers said, for section 3.0

APPENDIX 5: WITHDRAWAL FROM SEX EDUCATION: PROCESS, MEETING GUIDE AND DECISION

This appendix supports section 11.0. It is adapted for Futures Matter - Northwood from The Key's guidance on the right to withdraw, and from paragraphs 16 to 21 of the DfE's RSHE guidance.

What can and cannot be withdrawn.

- Parents and carers cannot withdraw their child from relationships education, health education, or science lessons that cover sex education topics.
- They can withdraw their child from some or all of sex education within RSHE. This means they can ask for a pupil to miss lessons on certain topics (for example, contraception) but attend others (for example, sexually transmitted infections).
- They can do this until three terms before the pupil turns 16. After that, the pupil can choose to opt back in, and we arrange this. We make sure pupils know about this option, during discussions with the family and pupil and again as the time comes.
- The only exception to granting a request is where the Head Teacher decides that there are exceptional circumstances (see Step 3).

How to ask. Parents and carers can submit a request using the online Google Form (link: **To confirm: add the Google Form link**), or by sending the paper form at Appendix 3 or a letter to the Head Teacher. The Google Form asks for:

- the pupil's name and year group
- the parent or carer's name, relationship to the pupil, and contact details
- which part or parts of sex education they wish the pupil to be withdrawn from (all, or specific topics from the curriculum map in Appendix 1)
- their reasons for the request (optional, but helpful because it lets us address concerns)
- whether they would like to meet the Head Teacher to talk about the request
- their signature (typed name) and the date

Responses go to a school-controlled spreadsheet that only the Head Teacher and the PSHCEE Lead can access. An automatic email confirms receipt. A copy of each request is placed in the pupil's file and logged on CPOMS or the school's records system.

Step 1: Meet the family. The Head Teacher offers a meeting, in person, by phone or by video call, within **To confirm: number of school days** of receiving the request. Parents and carers do not have to meet in order for the request to be processed. Where they agree, we send them a sample of the RSHE resources beforehand and offer to answer questions. We also explain what pupils learn about sex education in science, which cannot be withdrawn.

Step 2: Hold the meeting. In the meeting, the Head Teacher:

- asks why the parent or carer does not want the pupil to take part, and listens
- explains the benefits of sex education, including being on the same page as peers, and having an early foundation to help understand healthy relationships, sexual relationships and consent later in life
- explains the possible effects of withdrawal: the social and emotional impact on the pupil, the chance that they will hear peers' version of what was taught (which may be inaccurate), and a narrower understanding of topics like sex and consent, which

could make them more vulnerable to abuse. For our pupils, who may find social information harder to read, this is a particular concern
- asks what would make the parent or carer more comfortable with the pupil attending, for example a different resource or advance warning of the topic
- discusses what the pupil could do during the lessons, and asks for their and the pupil's ideas
- speaks with the pupil (where they are able and it is appropriate), so that their own wishes are heard, and makes sure the pupil knows they can opt back in three terms before they turn 16

We ask the family first if they are happy for a second member of staff to attend. Their job is to take notes, so the Head Teacher can give the family their full attention. The notes record the family's concerns, what might help them feel comfortable, and what the family would like the pupil to do instead. Notes are saved with the request.

Step 3: Decide. Before deciding, the Head Teacher considers each pupil individually and whether there are exceptional circumstances. There is no blanket rule. The Head Teacher asks:

- are there significant concerns about the pupil in terms of safeguarding, or significant vulnerabilities (for example, because of SEND, past experiences or other reasons)?
- does the pupil need to know certain things to look after themselves, keep themselves safe, or be able to say what has happened to them?

For example, if a pupil has been a victim of child-on-child sexual abuse, we may refuse the request if the pupil needs the vocabulary and understanding of sex education to recognise and disclose abuse in future. The Head Teacher, as Designated Safeguarding Lead, takes into account what is on the pupil's CPOMS record and EHC plan, and consults the pupil's key adult, therapeutic staff and placing local authority where appropriate. If a request is granted for a pupil whose EHC plan has outcomes on relationships or sexual health, we tell the placing local authority.

Step 4: Tell the family. We tell the family in person if possible, or by phone, and always in writing, so we have a record. The decision letter says:

- whether the request is approved or refused
- if refused, the reasons why
- if approved, what the pupil will do during the sex education lessons they will not attend, and which topics are covered
- that the pupil can opt back in from three terms before their 16th birthday

When we approve a request, the letter also says that we respect the family's wishes and still value them as part of our community, that we want to draw a line under the decision and move forward together, and that, even if we disagree about sex education, we are united in wanting what is best for their child and we are committed to giving them a full education.

Step 5: Provide alternative education. It is the school's responsibility to make sure that a withdrawn pupil has appropriate, purposeful education, of the same quality as other lessons, when sex education lessons take place. This might include:

- revision or catch-up work, or extension tasks from other subjects, or a research project
- independent reading

- life skills activities, such as cooking basics, first aid awareness and budgeting
- wellbeing journals, with guided reflections on goals, gratitude or managing stress
- digital literacy tasks, such as e-safety scenarios or a guide to safe online behaviour
- online learning games and activities that fit the pupil's interests

Where more than one pupil is withdrawn, we keep them together where possible so they do not feel isolated, and we may timetable the lessons together so that supervision is efficient. Supervision is by a member of staff known to the pupil (for example, a teaching assistant), in a quiet place with minimal disruption, such as a spare classroom or the library. The pupil's SEMH and communication needs are taken into account.

Step 6: Keep the relationship going. Families who withdraw their child may feel isolated from the school. The Head Teacher and the pupil's key adult keep in touch, include the family in other aspects of school life, and review the arrangement at the pupil's EHC plan annual review. We keep to our duty to give the pupil a full education.

Records. We keep the request, notes of discussions, the decision letter and the alternative learning plan together in one place, so that we can refer to them if there is a dispute, and show an inspector that we meet our statutory duties. The PSHCEE Lead keeps a log of requests (dates, year group, topics, outcome) and tells the Head Teacher if they notice a pattern, such as several families objecting to the same topic or resource, in which case we revisit the curriculum and resources and how we explain them.

Wider objections. Occasionally a parent or carer may object publicly to part of the curriculum or a specific resource, or contact the school or a governor with concerns. These are handled through the Head Teacher, who meets the person, explains what is taught and why, and refers them to the Complaints Policy if they remain concerned. We keep a record.

APPENDIX 6: SHARING RSHE MATERIALS WITH PARENTS AND CARERS

The statutory guidance says schools should make parents and carers aware of what is taught and show them a representative sample of resources. This appendix explains how we do this. Parents and carers cannot veto what we teach, but they are able to see all the materials used to teach RSHE if they ask.

What we share routinely.

- the RSHE policy and the curriculum map (Appendices 1 and 2), published on our website
- a representative sample of the resources we use, shared during the consultation and at induction
- information at EHC plan annual reviews about what we teach and when

How parents and carers can see all materials. They can ask the Head Teacher or the PSHCEE Lead at any time, by phone, email or by using the contact details on the consultation form. We will arrange one of the following, depending on what suits the family:

- viewing the materials in school, with a member of staff to answer questions
- a presentation or a one-to-one meeting
- an online link or secure parent portal **To confirm: whether we use a portal or shared Google Drive folder with view-only access**
- paper copies to take home, where appropriate

We ask that families respect copyright, and do not copy or share the materials further. This is to protect the resources and the pupils, not to prevent them being seen.

Curriculum map and resources. The Key's curriculum map template lists, for each year group and term, the topic and theme details and the resources used (with links or examples), and advises being as detailed and transparent as possible, because it makes questions and objections easier to handle. Our curriculum map (Appendix 1) lists the topics for each term. **To confirm: add a resources column to Appendix 1 giving the name of each resource and a link or example, before the consultation opens**

External providers. If our materials come from an external provider, we acknowledge the source. No contract or copyright can stop us from sharing materials with parents and carers. If a provider objects, we tell them that we are legally required to have regard to the statutory RSHE guidance, which says we should share all content with parents and carers.

Records. We note requests to see materials and the date we responded.

APPENDIX 7: RSHE REQUIREMENTS AT A GLANCE

This summary, adapted from The Key's guide to the RSHE requirements, is for staff, governors and anyone who wants to understand the legal context. It reflects the DfE's statutory guidance, which applies from 1 September 2026.

Our requirements.

- Schools with a secondary phase must provide relationships and sex education (RSE) and health education. As an independent school, health education is not compulsory for us because we are already required to provide PSHE, but we cover it in our curriculum.
- We must have an RSHE policy, consult parents and carers when we develop and review it, publish it on our website and give a copy to anyone who asks.
- We should make parents and carers aware of what we teach, show them a representative sample of resources, and let them see all the materials if they ask (Appendix 6).
- Parents and carers can ask to withdraw their child from some or all of sex education (Appendix 5), but not from relationships education, health education or science.

Flexibility in how we teach. The guidance allows us to personalise teaching for factors such as age, physical and emotional maturity, religious background and SEND. However:

- our teaching must reflect current law as it applies to relationships, so pupils understand what the law does and does not allow
- staff must comply with the Equality Act 2010 and the Public Sector Equality Duty (see our Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy), including understanding pupils' faith backgrounds and making sure all pupils understand the importance of equality and respect
- staff must comply with our legal duties on political impartiality, especially when working with external organisations or using their materials, because the school is responsible for what is said to pupils
- we build on what pupils learned in primary school

Biological sex, gender reassignment and LGBT topics. Our teaching covers:

- the facts and the law about biological sex and gender reassignment, including that people have legal rights because of their biological sex that are different from the rights of those of the opposite sex who have the protected characteristic of gender reassignment
- that all people with protected characteristics, including sexual orientation and gender reassignment, are protected from discrimination
- how to express views while respecting the opinions of others, and that bullying or disrespectful language or behaviour is never appropriate

Beyond the facts and the law there is significant debate, so we do not endorse any particular view or teach it as fact (for example, we do not teach as fact that all people have a gender identity), we avoid language and activities that repeat or enforce gender stereotypes, and we avoid any suggestion that social transition is a simple solution to feelings of distress. If we use external resources, we avoid materials that use cartoons or diagrams that oversimplify the topic, perpetuate stereotypes or encourage pupils to question their gender. We make sure there is equal opportunity to explore stable and healthy same-sex relationships, that sexual health is covered in a way that is relevant to lesbian, gay, bisexual and gender

questioning pupils, and that same-sex relationships are integrated into RSHE and not taught as a standalone unit.

Faith and belief. We respect pupils' faith and beliefs and handle topics sensitively, taking account of pupils' backgrounds when we plan teaching (see our Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy).

How Ofsted looks at RSHE. RSHE is not inspected as a separate area. It is covered under curriculum and teaching (whether we meet the statutory requirements) and personal development and wellbeing (how pupils' understanding of healthy relationships is developed). As an independent school we are also inspected against the Independent School Standards.